

Board: 1

Dealer: **West**

Contract: 3NT

Declarer: North

Lead: ♥ J

Board: 2

Dealer: **East**

Contract: 1NT

Declarer: East

Lead: ♥ Q

Board: 3

Dealer: **South**

Contract: 4 ♥

Declarer: South

Lead: ♠ A

Board: 4

Dealer: **South**

Contract: 3NT

Declarer: West

Lead: ♠ Q

Board 1

West Deals

None Vul

♠ A 7
 ♥ K 6 5 3
 ♦ 7 6 2
 ♣ 10 5 4 3

♠ K Q 10 3

♥ A 4

♦ Q J 10 5

♣ A J 2

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ 9 8 5 2
 ♥ J 10 9 8 2
 ♦ K 4
 ♣ 9 8

♠ J 6 4

♥ Q 7

♦ A 9 8 3

♣ K Q 7 6

West	North	East	South
Pass	1NT	Pass	3NT
All Pass			

3NT by North

Lead: ♥J

work. At trick 2 you lead your ♦Q, playing low from dummy if East doesn't cover. Repeat the finesse as necessary. When East has the ♦K you will make your contract, and when West has the ♦K you will go down. That's a 50% chance, just like most finesses. But remember, if you had tried to establish the ♠ suit instead of taking the finesse your chance of making 3NT would be 0%.

You can see what could have happened if you had tried to sneak even one ♠ trick. West would have grabbed the ♠A and played a small ♥. East would have happily taken 4 ♥ tricks and you would be down 1.

You have a very solid 17 points and a balanced hand. You open 1NT. Partner responds 3NT and you pass.

North plays 3NT. East leads the ♥J. You hopefully put on the ♥Q, but West plays the ♥K.

North plays 3NT. East leads the ♥J. You hopefully put on the ♥Q, but West plays the ♥K.

Winners: ♠ 0 : ♥ 1 : ♦ 1 : ♣ 4 : Total = 6

A hold-up won't help unless West had a doubleton ♥, giving East a 7-card suit. So you win your ♥A. The ♠ suit is solid after the ♠A is played, but before you could enjoy those 3 tricks the defenders would have really enjoyed a bunch of ♥s.

Your only hope is to win 8 more tricks before you lose the lead. That means the ♦ finesse had better

Board 2

East Deals

N-S Vul

♠ Q 10 9 8
♥ A 5
♦ 7 5 4 2
♣ 9 7 3

♠ J 7 5 4

♥ 9 6

♦ K Q 10 9

♣ Q 8 4



♠ A 2

♥ K 7 4 2

♦ A 8 6 3

♣ A 10 5

♠ K 6 3

♥ Q J 10 8 3

♦ J

♣ K J 6 2

West

North

East

South

1NT

All Pass

1NT by East

Lead: ♥Q

Win the first trick with the ♥K. Then play ♠A followed by ♠2. Continue playing ♠s until the ♠K is forced out. Win whatever they play next and play your other winners. You cannot be stopped from taking 7 tricks.

Imagine what would have happened if you had taken the first trick with dummy's ♥A.

What would you try next? A ♠ finesse? Whether South took his ♠K right then or later you would go down. You could never reach dummy again.

You have 7 points so you know your side does not have a game. You also have no reason to think there is any better contract than 1NT. So you pass.

West would play 1NT. To make life more convenient the hands will be rotated so that East becomes declarer.

East plays 1NT. South leads the ♥Q.

East plays 1NT. South leads the ♥Q.

Winners: ♠ 1 : ♥ 2 : ♦ 1 : ♣ 1 : Total = 5

You need two more winners. Even if the ♦s split 3-2 you can get only one more from that suit. So clearly you must use the ♠ suit. Since you have only one entry to dummy you must save it until the right time.

Board 3

South Deals

None Vul

♠ A K 7 3

♥ 8 4 2

♦ J 9 3

♣ 10 8 4

♠ 10 6 4

♥ K Q 7

♦ 8 6

♣ J 7 5 3 2



♠ 9 8 2

♥ 5

♦ Q 10 7 4 2

♣ A K 9 6

♠ Q J 5

♥ A J 10 9 6 3

♦ A K 5

♣ Q

West

North

East

South

Pass

2♥

Pass

4♥

All Pass

4♥ by South

Lead: ♠ A

You have a nice hand, but 20 points is not strong enough to open 2♣.

So you open 1♥. Partner raises to 2♥.

Partner's raise to 2♥ shows 6-10 points. You figure that should be enough for game but even if he has the full 10 you are not in slam range. So you bid the game.

South plays 4♥. West leads ♠ A, then switches to ♥ 2.

South plays 4♥. West leads ♠ A, then switches to ♥ 2.

Losers: ♠ 2 : ♥ 0 : ♦ 1 : ♣ 1 : Total = 4

It's a good thing you stopped at game - partner's hand is about as bad as it could be.

The PLAN turns out simple. You can't avoid either of the three black losers so you must eliminate the ♦ loser. You can ruff it in dummy. Just to be safe you pull one more round of trumps, then play ♦ A, ♦ K and ♦ 5, ruffing in dummy. You will eventually get to your hand (with a ♠ or a ♣ ruff) and pull the last trump.

This PLAN was not difficult.

Only a real beginner would have pulled all the trumps and not been able to ruff that ♦.

Board 4

South Deals

Both Vul

♠ A 9
♥ A J 2
♦ Q J 3
♣ J 10 8 6 2

♠ Q J 10 8 2

♥ 10 8 6

♦ 7 5 4

♣ A 5



♠ 7 4
♥ K 5 3
♦ A K 9 6 2
♣ K Q 3

♠ K 6 5 3

♥ Q 9 7 4

♦ 10 8

♣ 9 7 4

West	North	East	South
1 ♣	Pass	1 ♦	Pass
1NT	Pass	3NT	Pass
All Pass			
3NT by West			
Lead: ♠ Q			

With 16 points as Responder you are not quite strong enough for a jump-shift to 2 ♦. That requires at least 17 points. A jump to 3NT fits the point range (16-18) but promises a stopper in all unbid suits. So instead you bid 1 ♦, knowing partner is forced to keep the bidding alive. He now replies 1NT. What is your next bid?

Until now you were thinking the hand might end up in a slam. Now, with partner's minimum rebid, you happily say 3NT which partner passes.

East would play 3NT.

West plays 3NT. North leads the ♠ Q. South puts on the ♠ K.

West plays 3NT. North leads the ♠ Q. South puts on the ♠ K.

Winners: ♠ 1 : ♥ 2 : ♦ 5 : ♣ 0 : Total = 8

Let's say you hold up on the first ♠, hoping they switch suits. HA! They aren't about to switch suits and they drive out your ♠ A at trick 2. That actually clears the situation up and makes this plan pretty simple to make.

You have taken 1 ♠, and you will surely make 5 ♦ s. Despite the solidity of those ♣ s you dare not try to win a ♣ trick, because the defenders will pounce on that first ♣ and then win a bunch of ♠ tricks.

So that makes it clear that you need 3 ♥ tricks, and there's only one way to get them. After taking your five ♦ tricks, play a ♥ to the ♥ K, then a ♥ back, finessing the ♥ J. Half of the time you will make this contract, the other half of the time they will bury you with ♠ s.

You might think if you could just sneak one ♣ through you wouldn't have to depend on the ♥ finesse. But put yourself in North's chair. Do you really think he will let you win a ♣ when he sees he can defeat you by taking his ♣ A and leading ♠ winners?